

Authoring with Adobe FrameMaker

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ABSTRACT

This report examines the technical writing tool, Adobe FrameMaker, and its features that help with authoring technical documents. This tool was examined through the informational pages provided by Adobe on their features. Through the vast amount of informational pages provided by Adobe, this report focuses on four features. Those features are structured authoring, templates, multichannel publishing, and importing and linking. All of these features help users in authoring their documents. Overall, Adobe FrameMaker stands out as it offers diverse tools for technical writers to use in their documents.

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Adobe FrameMaker serves as a comprehensive content authoring solution created for individual users and teams. This technical writing tool has a range of features, including templates, multichannel publishing, and importing/linking. This formal report is made for technical writing students and professors to introduce structured authoring on Adobe FrameMaker and highlight some of its features.

Founded in 1982 by John Warnock and Charles Geschke, Adobe Incorporated now offers a variety of tools for the technical writer, including Adobe FrameMaker. This tool helps technical writers with their authoring and publishing needs. With Adobe FrameMaker, technical writers, and other users, can:

- Author and enrich content
- Manage collaborations
- Publish across multiple channels

Structured authoring is a part of what makes Adobe FrameMaker work. On Adobe FrameMaker, structured authoring works through employing content rules, defined as a DTD or XML Scheme, that maintain a consistent structure through the project(s). An example of this would be having a title for all topics/subtopics. Structured authoring provides benefits to Adobe FrameMaker users, such as enforcing organization and automatically confirming the organization of information.

For a consistent layout and format, Adobe FrameMaker offers templates for the documents of their users. The two types of templates offered are unstructured and structured. Unstructured templates incorporate formatting information within element definitions, page layouts for column positioning, and document-wide settings like footnote properties. Structured templates, however, are designed for various document types, such as letters, memos, faxes, reports, and FAQs. These templates include element definitions, variables for updated text placeholders, formatting details for conditional tags and cross-referencing, and color definitions for objects and text.

Multichannel publishing is a crucial part of what makes Adobe FrameMaker what it is. In the current work environment, content authors face the challenge of creating and publishing content that is accessible across diverse devices. Adobe FrameMaker addresses this need through its multichannel publishing feature, enabling users to write content once and publish it in various formats.

Importing/Linking is an essential element in making the user's document what they dream. Importing in Adobe FrameMaker allows the inclusion of documents or files, created within FrameMaker or externally, into the current document. This can be done through methods such as copying to the clipboard and pasting, as well as drag-and-drop from the original location to the current one. The subscription cost can be billed monthly or annually. For individuals, the subscription is \$39.99/mo. or \$479.88/yr. If team leaders or any educators would like a subscription, they should request a callback.

INTRODUCTION

Adobe FrameMaker works as a content authoring solution designed to support complex authoring environments and publishing needs. It offers authoring tools to be accessible to individual users and teams. The purpose of Adobe FrameMaker is to take care of all its users' authoring and publishing needs. This formal report's scope includes introducing structured authoring and elements offered on Adobe FrameMaker ("Adobe FrameMaker," 2022). The elements involved in this report include:

- Templates
- Multichannel Publishing
- Importing and Linking

This document is intended for technical writing professors and students.

Adobe

Adobe Incorporated was founded in December 1982 by John Warnock and Charles Geschke to create products that could accurately translate text and images from screen-to-page (*See Figure A*). In the 1980s, Warnock and Geschke focused Adobe on developing the Adobe PostScript page description language, becoming the standard for computer printing international, before moving into the creation of Photoshop in 1989 and the Portable Document Format (PDF) in 1993 (Wikipedia contributors, 2024). Today, Adobe offers innovative technology, including Adobe FrameMaker, that empowers everyone to create and bring digital experiences to life.

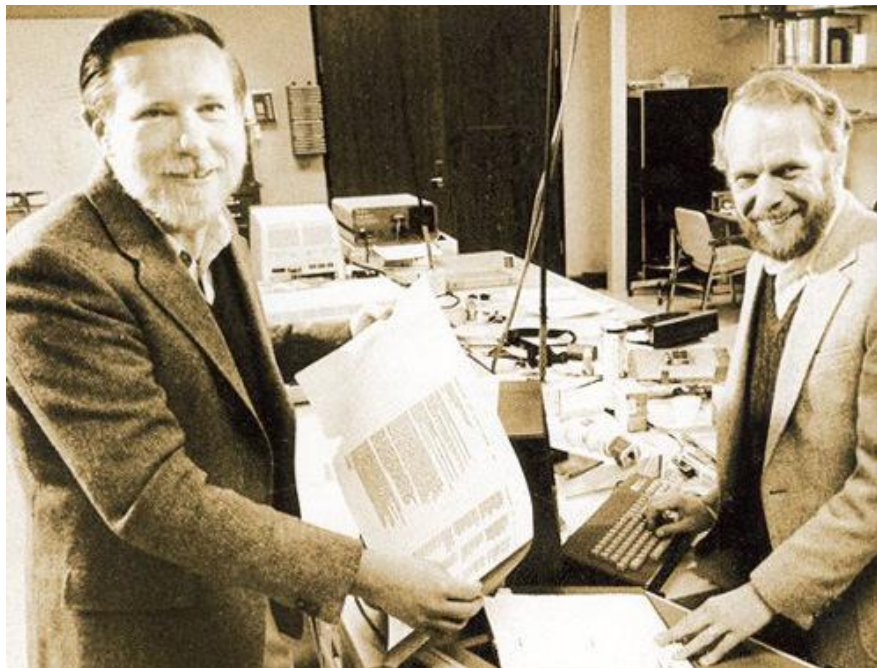


Figure A – Adobe Founders

John Warnock and Charles Geschke in 1982. Image retrieved from Hongkiat.com.

ADOBE FRAMEMAKER

Adobe FrameMaker is a technical writing tool that offers a solution for various authoring and publishing needs. Through FrameMaker, users can author and enrich content, manage and collaborate, and publish across multiple channels. With the "author and enrich" settings, it provides content, tables, graphics, and media that can be used in the projects. Managing and collaborating allows technical writers to have control over their project lifecycles, reviews, and collaborations. The "publishing" features let technical users publish their authored documents for an array of devices, including iOS, Android, and Kindle (“Adobe FrameMaker,” n.d.).

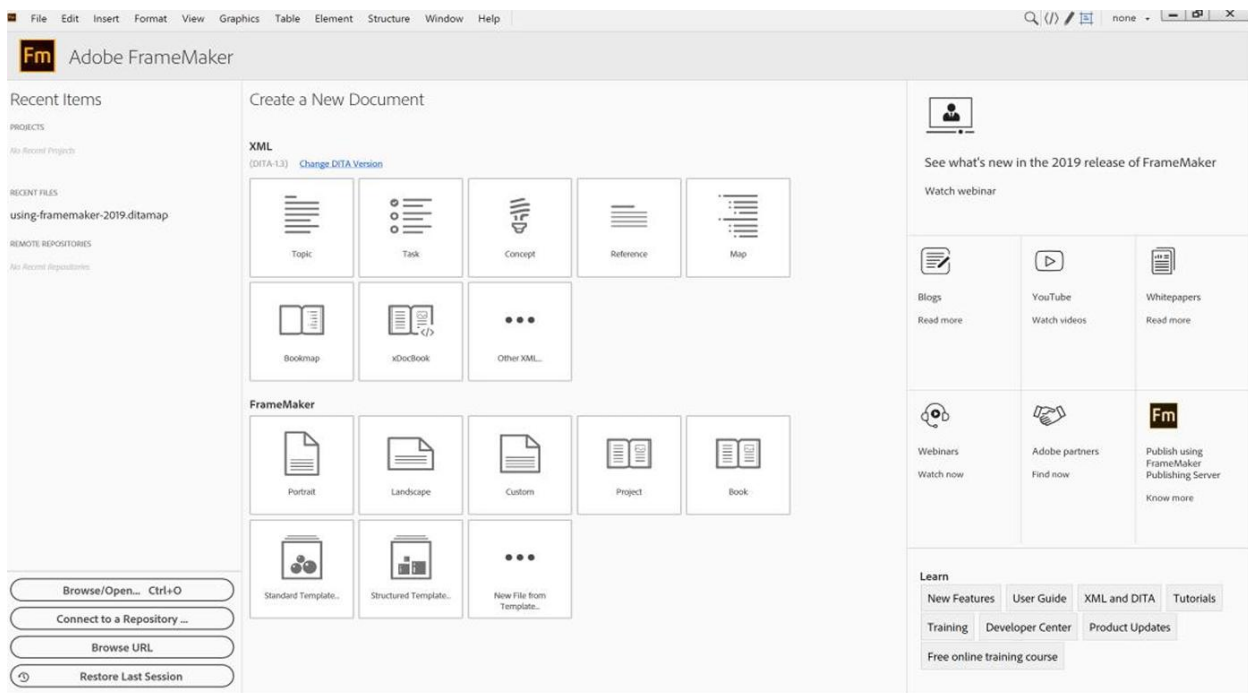


Figure B – Introduction to FrameMaker

The Welcome Screen that appears when you launch FrameMaker. Image retrieved from help.adobe.com.

The hardware and software needed to use Adobe FrameMaker are:

- Core i5 or faster processor
- 64-bit version
- Microsoft Windows Operating System 10 and Up
- 4 GB or higher RAM (recommended)
- 64 GB of hard-disk space available during installation
- JRE 8

FrameMaker is available in English, French, German, and Japanese (“System Requirements”, 2022)

Structured Authoring

Structured authoring uses content rules to enforce a consistent structure across the project. Their content rules are defined as a Document Type Definition (DTD) or an Extensible Markup Language (XML) Schema. An example of a project having structured authoring is:

- Every topic starts with a title
- A paragraph following each title
- Every graphic has a caption

These rules are automatically checked for conformity through the DTD or XML Schema.

When using FrameMaker, you can import and export structured documents using two formats: Standard Generalized Markup Language (SGML) and XML. SGML is the international standard for all markup languages in data exchange and storage. It is a descriptive markup language. What this means is that it allows different systems to process the same document. XML is a generalized format for how structured information is represented for the web. It is extensible. This means that you can define your elements and their order, relationships, and the way they are processed and displayed. SGML and XML are both able to define and enforce a structure appropriate for your content, including conforming to a DTD structure (“Structured Authoring,” 2022).

Some of the benefits of structured authoring are:

- Consistent organization being enforced
- The organization of information can be automatically validated
- Ensures content consistency
- Separates content and formatting
- Reduces localization efforts
- Supports the use of metadata that adds information to documents

Templates

Adobe FrameMaker offers templates that you can use when creating a document to give it all, or some, of the same qualities as the template. Templates can help make your document consistent in the layout and format. FrameMaker offers unstructured and structured templates. An unstructured template can include:

- Formatting information within the element definitions that works with paragraph, character, and table formats
- Page layouts that help determine the number and position of columns on page
- Graphics and formatting information that is stored in reference pages
- Document wide settings, such as footnote properties and feathering options for line spacing

A structured template is used for letters, memos, faxes, reports, FAQs, and more (*See Figure C*).

A structured template can include:

- Element definitions that allow contents, attributes, and formatting for elements
- Variables that can be used as placeholders for text that FrameMaker updates
- Formatting information for conditional tags and cross-referencing
- Definitions for colors you can apply to objects and/or text (“Templates,” 2022)

Create a New Document Using Structured Templates

Choose from the list on the left. Then click a button on the right.

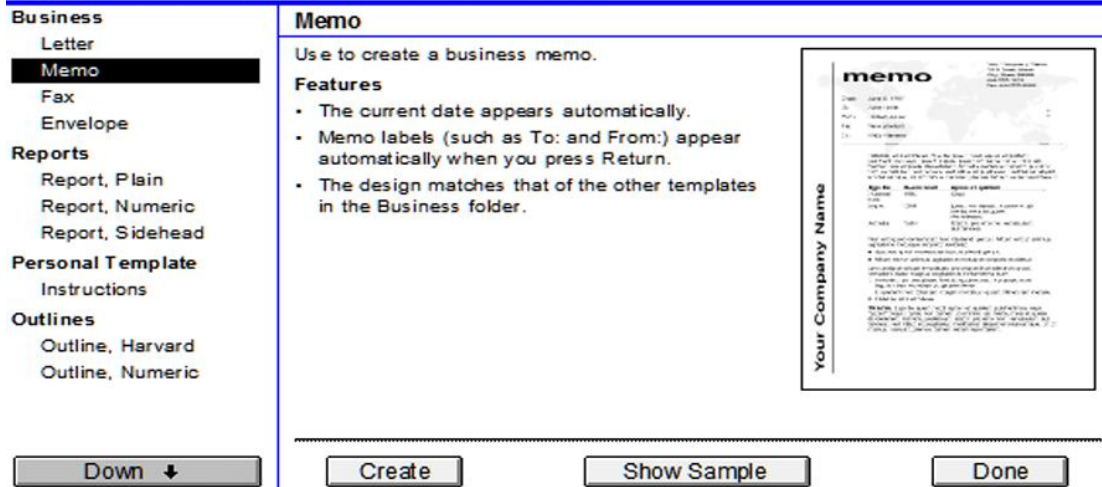


Figure C – Structured Template

The screen shows what templates can be used for and samples. Image retrieved from helpx.adobe.com.

Multichannel Publishing

In today’s world, content authors need to write and publish content that is readable across a variety of devices. Multichannel publishing on Adobe FrameMaker enables users to write content once and publish it onto multiple formats. This allows you to publish on multiple formats, including:

- PDF Responsive
- HTML5
- Mobile App
- EPUB
- Kindle

The process of multichannel publishing on FrameMaker (See Figure D) allows easy customization of your content’s style and setting for multiple outputs. The outputs in Adobe FrameMaker are highly customizable (“Multichannel publishing,” 2022).

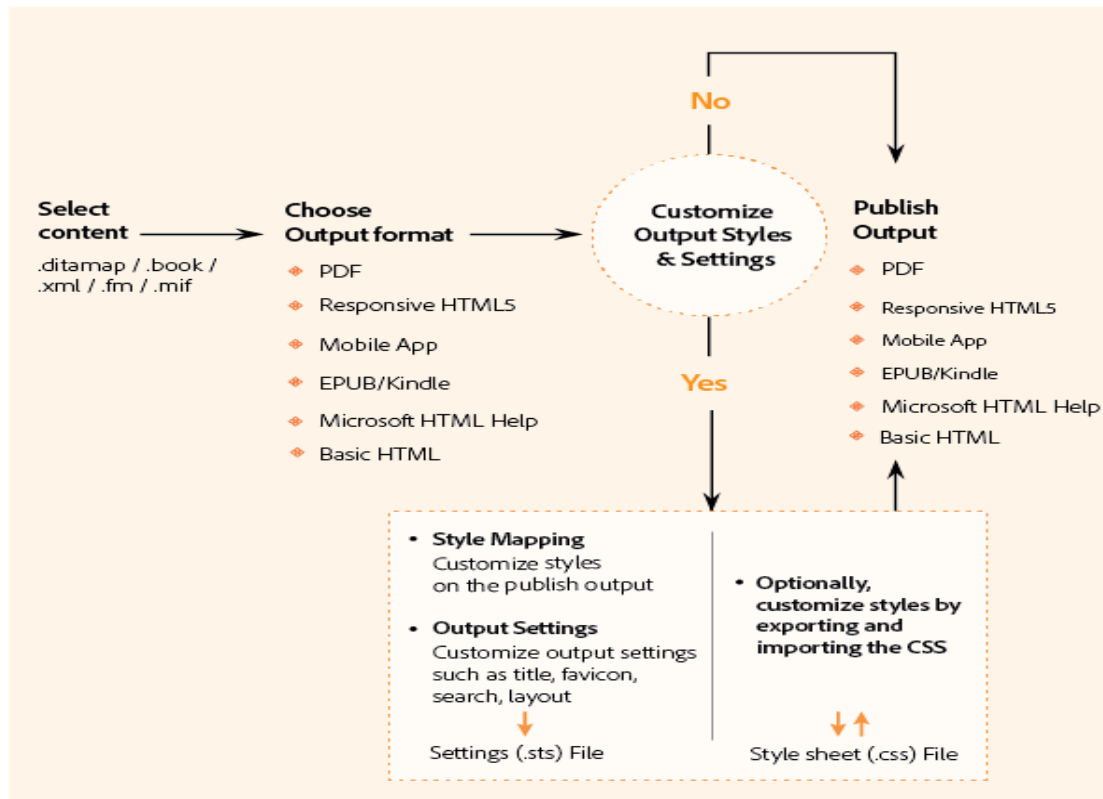


Figure D – Output Styles

This displays the process of customizing your output’s styles and settings. Image retrieved from help.adobe.com.

Importing and Linking

Importing on Adobe FrameMaker allows copying another document or file, whether made on FrameMaker or not, into your current document. It can also be linked, so it can remain tied to its source to ease updating. Some ways a document can be imported is through:

- Clipboard: Copy it to your clipboard and paste it into its new location
- Drag-and-Drop: Move the object from its original location to its new location
- Reference: Select the chosen file and import it through the “Import B Reference” button (“Import and link methods,” 2022)

Users can also import a variety of graphics and images into a FrameMaker document (“Import Graphics,” 2022). Some of the most commonly used image file formats that can be imported into FrameMaker are:

- Adobe Illustrator
- Adobe Photoshop
- Adobe PDF
- Portable Network Graphics (PNG)
- Graphic Interchange Format (GIF)

CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

In conclusion, Adobe FrameMaker is a versatile authoring solution that caters to the needs of content authors, offering a comprehensive array of features for authoring and publishing. From its templates to its importing/linking, Adobe FrameMaker works to make the job of a technical writer easier. In addition to Adobe FrameMaker, it seems to be a worthy idea if users would also use Adobe Illustrator and Adobe Photoshop to enhance the flexibility of the service. Overall, Adobe FrameMaker empowers content authors with efficient, collaborative, and customizable tools for their diverse authoring and publishing needs.

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GLOSSARY

Authoring- “one that originates or creates something”

SGML- “a markup language used to define the structure of and manage documents in electronic form”

Template- “a document that stores properties that are used in more than one place”

XML- “a markup language with use and design similar to HTML but employing tags defined by the user that can be used to indicate both the logical structure and the display specifications of the coded data”

Definitions retrieved from Merriam-Webster dictionary (https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/authoring?utm_campaign=sd&utm_medium=serp&utm_source=jsonld) and the Adobe FrameMaker “template” page (https://help.adobe.com/en_US/frame maker/using/using-frame maker/user-guide/topic_templates.html#topic_templates)